

RAYMONDE CARROLL

Cultural Misunderstandings

THE FRENCH-AMERICAN EXPERIENCE

Translated by Carol Volk

THE UNIVERSITY OF CHICAGO PRESS
Chicago and London

1 Home

Several years ago, an American anthropologist returning from France, where he had spent the summer on his way back from Africa, told me that what had really struck him was the distrustfulness of the French, who always kept their shutters closed. Just the idea of shutters . . . They made the streets particularly gloomy, as if the villages were uninhabited, or as if people were spying on you from behind them (This anthropologist did not do research in France.)

When my mother came to visit me in the United States, she liked the style of American houses, the way they stood separate from each other, the big lawns, the architectural diversity, the space. One day, we were quietly seated in the living room when she suddenly became aware of the large bay window and, visibly shocked, said to me, "My goodness, you live in the street!" And I understood exactly what she was feeling. It took me years to get used to "living in the street." And when I stroll around my neighborhood in the evening, I am still somewhat surprised at being able to see right into each home. People read, watch television, throw parties, eat dinner, do the dishes, or whatever without closing their drapes, and they are apparently not the least bit bothered by the possibility of a stranger's eyes peering into their lives. And even today, I'm the one who always closes the drapes in our home, much to the amusement of my American husband.

The lawns surrounding American houses display this same refusal to separate the street and the house. In certain American cities the sidewalk itself disappears, the lawn ends where the street begins, and the owner of the house is responsible for its upkeep (as he or she would be for the upkeep of the sidewalk). Space substitutes for walls, railings, or fences, which are sometimes replaced by bushes or trees. But the

cutoff point is not clearly defined. Thus, in spring and summer, it is common to see passing strollers sit awhile on your lawn to rest, without, however, going beyond an implicit limit. Backyards and gardens blend into each other in certain small American cities, but more often they are separated by low hedges, across which neighbors exchange produce from their gardens or simply chat. According to an old American tradition, when a family moves into a neighborhood the neighbors immediately come to welcome them, bringing hot coffee and cakes. I benefited from this type of welcome in two different cities, each with over one hundred thousand inhabitants. (I'm speaking here about moving into houses, not apartments.)

We can therefore understand an American's surprise when faced with the walls, gates, shutters, and drawn curtains that "protect" French houses, as well as the uneasiness of a French person before these "open" American houses. But these differences do not really cause any problems. It is inside the house that blunders or misunderstandings have a greater chance of arising.

Dick and Jill are invited to dinner at Pierre and Jeanne's. The conversation becomes lively during cocktails. Pierre speaks enthusiastically about a book he thinks would interest Dick a great deal. He has it fact, and goes to look for it in his study. He is taken aback, as he heads toward the room, when he realizes that Dick is following him. Jeanne goes to the kitchen to check if something is burning. She is just as taken aback when she sees Jill walk in right behind her. Jill offers to help. "No, no thank you, everything is ready . . ." Or at the end of the meal, Jill gets up to clear the table and carries the dishes into the kitchen, or else Dick offers to do the dishes. Pierre and Jeanne protest; if they are unfamiliar with American habits, they might very well consider Jill and Dick to be "intrusive" or "inconsiderate," or they might be "ashamed" that Dick or Jill has seen the rooms "in a terrible mess." ("But what could I do? I wasn't expecting him to follow me all over the house, I didn't know how to stop him.") In fact, it would have sufficed to say "I'll be back in a minute" for Dick not to have gotten up, for him not to have felt obliged to accompany Pierre because Pierre was going out of his way for him.

French people are often surprised when, the first time they enter an American home, their hosts show them around the house, and they interpret this as "showing off." Without excluding this possibility, it is

important to understand that an American considers this an attempt to make you "feel at home" by immediately giving you an opportunity to orient yourself, so to speak. Thus, instead of taking your coat when you arrive at a party, the host will show you in which bedroom and on what floor "the coats go." This, among other things, allows you to check your hair, or whatever you like, in the bathroom mirror next door. And if the party is a success, it will spill over into every room on the ground floor, with a definite preference for the kitchen. Guests serve themselves at the bar set up for the occasion (unless the party is more "formal"), help themselves to beer from the refrigerator—in short, they try hard to do as much as they can by themselves so as not to "bother" their host, who also has a right to have fun. This means that the cupboards and drawers are likely to be opened and closed freely, which would give French people the sense that they were being "intruded upon" or that their guests had "been all over the place."

These few examples, and there are many others, already show how different the relationship to the home is in these two cultures.

A French informant told me that he had never entered the kitchen at his grandmother's house, where he ate lunch once a week, until she became very old and less mobile and resigned herself to sending him to get things from the kitchen during meals. While the division between public and private is clearly marked outside the house by its division from the street, thanks to the walls, gates, and drawn curtains mentioned earlier, it is not so clearly marked inside the French home. But the dividing line, though implicit, exists just the same.

One can, in fact, determine the degree of intimacy between two people if one knows to which rooms one person has access in the other's house. The unknown person, the stranger, stays at the door. The next step consists in access to the foyer, then to the living room, then to the dining room (and, if need be, to the toilet). Many visitors will never go any further. A child's friends may have access to the room of that child, as well as to the kitchen for something to drink or for a snack, if they are regular guests in the house. The bathroom, which is separate from the toilet, is off-limits and is reserved for those who could be invited to spend the night. The refrigerator, the closets and the drawers are rarely accessible, except to those considered to be true "intimates" of the house. The room that remains sacred is the parents' bedroom. Of course we are talking about a house that has all these rooms, but space is not the significant factor in this context.

Rather, it is the way in which this space is opened, or not opened, to all those who are not part of the "immediate" family (comprised of the parents and children). Thus, if my father-in-law or mother-in-law, or even my father or mother, lives under my roof, that does not automatically give him or her access to my bedroom. On the contrary. "Well brought up" French people know all this. But one can easily imagine the misunderstandings that can arise when Americans are invited to French homes or when they live (as students) with French families for a period of time.

Similarly, there are misunderstandings in the reverse direction, which may seem surprising given the "relaxed" attitude with which Americans receive guests. A French writer, whose name I will not mention, wrote a book explaining Americans to the French. He enthusiastically tells us that when the lady of the house receives you wearing curlers, it is precisely to make you relax and "feel at home." No problem up to that point. The writer, grateful and admiring, describes the comfort of the room reserved for him, mentions the small touches like letter paper and stamps on the desk. Then the maid (rather a rare character, except in certain social spheres) asks him if he is going to dine with his hosts, and what he would like for dinner. The first evening, he tells us, he goes down to eat with his hosts. Then the second evening, because of the "relaxed" attitude and "kindness" of his hosts, and because he has a great deal of work to do, he decides to eat dinner in his room and "orders a steak and french fries from the maid."

If the writer in question actually did this, his hosts undoubtedly respected his wishes. But it is also more than likely that they attributed his request to "the well-known arrogance" of the French, or at least that they were deeply shocked by the "vulgarity" of this French person, whom, nevertheless, they would never think of enlightening as to his "monstrous" blunder. (The two questions he was asked probably mean "Are you planning to go out for dinner?" and "We'll do our best to please you," or something of that nature.) An unfortunate misunderstanding crowns the best of intentions in this case: the writer-character comes off as a boor, whereas it is his enthusiasm for American hospitality (as he understands it) that makes him unknowingly behave in an impolite fashion.

The misunderstanding is easy to comprehend. Indeed, when you are a house guest in an American home, your hosts immediately show

you your room, the "bathroom" (which includes the toilet), the place where towels are kept (or where you can get new ones, if there are already some in your room), the kitchen, including everything you need to make a cup of coffee or tea if you wake up in the middle of the night, and, finally, the refrigerator. At the same time, they invite you to "make yourself at home" and to "help yourself to anything you want." It is therefore possible that one's enthusiasm for "so much openness" might leave one with the impression of having all the advantages of a hotel at home, and that this would result in one's taking the invitation not to stand on ceremony literally. It is, in fact, almost impossible, without cultural analysis, to know where the line is drawn, a line which remains completely implicit. All the Americans to whom I told this story were shocked by the blunder, surprised that such a mistake was possible. One need only, however, carry the logic beyond the invisible line to make such an error.

An American student who spent a year living with a French family told me that an uncomfortable situation had developed toward the end of her stay, that there had been a kind of estrangement, for reasons which she did not understand. After she answered all kinds of questions from me, we reconstructed the misunderstanding as follows. At the beginning of her stay, as she did not yet know the family, she spent a good deal of time chatting with the mother and children on returning from school, before going to work in her room. Since she didn't feel quite comfortable yet, she kept the door to her room open. Much later, when she thought that she had become "a member of the family" and really felt at home, she (unconsciously) began acting exactly as she did at home. That is, on returning from school, she simply said hello and went directly to her room to work, automatically closing one door. It was at this point that the family, who must have felt she was rejecting them without understanding why, began to treat her with greater distance, "like a foreigner." Only after our discussion did she realize that what was for her a kind of compliment to the family (they made her feel at home) was on the contrary an insult (undeserved, and therefore all the more baffling) to the family, who had treated her as one of them.

Another student, this time one who lived in a small hotel which had been transformed into a residence for foreign students, told me of an unpleasant experience which she didn't understand. This story, once again, involves a door. One Saturday morning, as neither she

nor her roommate had classes, they told the cleaning woman that they would make their beds themselves because they wanted to sleep late. The cleaning woman, according to them, left looking very angry. The following Saturday, in order to assure that they would not be awakened, they put a "do not disturb" sign on the outer doorknob. This in no way stopped the cleaning woman, who knocked and entered. The two young women didn't stop her, because "the only other solution, which is very difficult for Americans, would have been to tell her to leave." What shocked them most of all was that the cleaning woman knocked and entered almost simultaneously, without giving them a chance to answer. What they considered to be an inviolable space, a room with a closed door, was simply invaded, as if by right. The student who told me of this experience summarized the source of the misunderstanding in this way: "In France, people knock on the door to announce that they are entering, whereas in the United States, it is to ask for permission to enter (for which one must wait) or to make certain the room is empty." I myself remember that, after having spent several years in the United States, I was shocked when a new colleague, who had just arrived from France, knocked and "barged into" my office. Everyone else waited for a "come in," including French people who had been living in the United States for a longer period of time.

A young American, who was boarding with a family in the sixteenth arrondissement in Paris, began, he says, to "behave like a member of the family" until the day when, to his great disappointment, the mother told him that she had rented him the room for purely economic reasons and not to establish a quasi-familial relationship with him. He could not understand how one could have someone in one's home and at one's table and at the same time treat that person "like a stranger." In an equivalent case in the United States, a family who rents a room to a student gives him access to the kitchen ("kitchen privileges") but not to the dining table without a special invitation. A permanent invitation to share the family meal calls for "member of the family" behavior, which undoubtedly explains why the "pension" system does not exist nowadays in most places.

A French student in the United States explained to another French woman, in my presence, that she had moved into a room she liked very much and which an American professor, known for his fine

cooking, rented to her. When the woman asked if she ate with the professor's family, the student protested, with both an amused and indignant air, "Oh, no! He made it clear that meals were not part of the deal, and that I shouldn't feel tempted, no matter what kinds of smells emanated from the kitchen. . . . He promised to invite me to dinner. . . . I can't wait." The dividing line had been clearly indicated in this particular case—a rare occurrence. But this clarification did not seem to have prevented the French student from feeling somewhat ruffled, so difficult it is to get used to the assumptions of others. It is all the more difficult for a French person to understand this attitude, since "everyone knows" that Americans invite "people they meet on the street" to dinner, "warmly" open their homes to people they hardly know, easily lend their houses to friends so that friends of their friends, whom they don't know, can use it in their absence. The nonexistence of the boarding system can be explained by the fact that an American will easily put his possessions and himself at your disposal if you are his guest but will not agree to "sell" you his services right inside his home, to give you the rights of a "paying customer" over him and over his freedom. In the French family, everyone usually eats dinner together. The meal must therefore be prepared in any case, and one more person at the table doesn't make much difference. In the American family, on the other hand, it is possible for each family member to eat dinner separately on certain evenings, when it is most convenient for her or him, because schedules are often difficult to coordinate. Having a boarder and owing him or her a meal every day would demand more of the "parents" than the children do themselves.

It is now clear that French and American houses differ not only on the exterior. Their differences are in fact reproduced, but less visibly, inside the house. The distinct separation between the inside and the outside in French culture anticipates the barriers to be crossed once inside. Access to different rooms denotes the path toward intimacy, so to speak, and corresponds to the visible/invisible division. What I mean is that the rooms which are "off limits" are closed and hidden from the eyes of those who have not been specifically admitted. By the same token, someone who stands close to a window, perfectly visible from the street, should adopt an "outside" form of behavior, even though he is separated from the outside by the window.

On the other hand, the American house is as open to strangers as it is visible from the street. In the evening, lit up on a dark street, it even attracts attention. If this does not seem to bother an American, it is because such openness in no way encroaches on his privacy, which he defines by setting up the barriers of his choice—by closing the door to his room, by surrounding himself by huge lawns or thick trees, by refusing all boarders, or simply by stopping you on your way to a room by saying "I'd rather you didn't see the mess," or "I'll be right back." Fences, walls, and high hedges give him the impression of being closed in and seem to deprive him of the spectacle of the street, the forest, or the beach bordering his house. And he will consider as an invasion of his privacy any intrusion made without his knowledge or against his wishes (electronic surveillance, of course, but also a door opened without waiting for permission, and the like). An American colleague does not enter your office without being invited: he or she remains on the threshold, even if the door is wide open. If your window is near the street, passersby will make it their business "not to see you," and if by chance your gazes meet through the window, they will smile or make a friendly gesture as if to say that they were looking into your house "by accident."

If I take the logic of the preceding analysis to its limit, I obtain two literally inverse situations. In French culture, the person who enters my house is responsible for knowing the rules, for remaining within the spatial limits that our relationship authorizes. (Thus I must be wary of a stranger who would invite me to skip some steps, to penetrate the depths of his house immediately.) I therefore have no defense against guests who feel "at ease" in my home, like Americans who follow me into the kitchen. In American culture, on the other hand, I am the one who is responsible for indicating the limits beyond which a person entering my house must not venture. What is troubling for French people is that these limits can change according to my mood. Here is an example: Tom (American) is putting up the parents of his wife (French), who are vacationing in the United States. On certain evenings, Tom is "charming" and sociable, whereas on others he comes from from work, barely says hello, takes a beer from the refrigerator ("without even offering them one"), sinks into his chair, and reads the paper. In this case, Tom, for personal reasons which, according to American culture, he need not explain, is indicating that

he does not want his "space," his privacy, to be invaded. It is very probable that Tom would behave in exactly the same way in the absence of his in-laws, that his desire for solitude has nothing to do with them. But the in-laws, not knowing how to interpret this message, are hurt and do not understand why Tom "has them at his home, only to treat them this way."

As we can see, hardly have we crossed the threshold when the intercultural misunderstandings begin. We can easily imagine that these won't be the last.

2 Conversation

We are driving in a car. X (French) is taking me home. It is not for the first time, and, what is more, X is quite familiar with the city. Yet X seems to be unsure of the correct route to follow and asks me questions which obviously do not call for an answer, since he asks them just as he is taking the action which the answer could influence—for example, “Do I turn here?” just as he is turning. Often, commentaries on the car, the road, other cars, and surprising expressions of concern come from behind the wheel (“Do you think I have enough gas?”; “What’s this guy doing, is he going to change lanes or not?”; “I’m sure we can’t squeeze between these two cars, but I’m gonna try”; “I should have gone the other way, we’d be there already”; etc.). X’s case is not unique. I’ve witnessed many variations on this scene. The participants were men as well as women, young as well as old. As soon as I became aware of it, I even caught myself “in the act.”

Do French people speak without saying anything, as Americans sometimes accuse them of doing? Is X’s pseudomonologue as devoid of meaning as it seems?

Another context: a party, in a university town in the United States, in honor of a well-known French academic. The host and most of the guests are French. There are a few scattered Americans. The French academic, who has just been introduced to an American historian, looks interested. “I’m very interested in history . . . Are you familiar with Z (famous American historian)?” “Yes.” “What do you think of his latest book?” The American responds, talking about what he thinks of the book in question. The Frenchman, having stopped listening at a certain point, is glancing around the living room, and he eagerly

widens the circle when another Frenchman approaches and “brutally interrupts” the conversation with a joke. The newcomer turns to the American, “What are you working on right now?” The latter, who has learned his lesson, responds briefly with “Oh, the same thing” and makes a joke.

This little scene was described to me by the American in question, who added, “I really don’t understand French people; they only pretend to ask questions. This behavior especially surprised me coming, as it did, from such a famous man. He had no need to ask the question if he wasn’t interested in the answer. Of course I wasn’t going to fall into the same trap twice, so I joked ‘French-style’ instead of answering.”

Americans often expressed surprise in my presence at the fact that French people, “who claim to be very big on manners,” are themselves so “rude”: “they interrupt you all the time in conversation,” “they finish your sentences for you,” “they ask you questions and never listen to the answer,” and so on. French people, on the other hand, often complain that American conversations are “boring,” that Americans respond to the slightest question with a “lecture,” that they “go all the way back to Adam and Eve,” and that they “know nothing about the art of conversation.”

The mutual accusations come up often enough to claim our attention. What they indicate must be a cultural phenomenon, opaque to the foreigner. They suggest a profound difference in the interpretation of conversation—a daily activity which appears clear-cut, familiar, and immediately accessible. But although the word “conversation” is the same in French and in English, it is far from signifying the same thing in the two cultures. That there is misunderstanding is moreover apparent in the fact that the (French) journal *Communications* dedicated an entire issue to this subject (no. 30, 1979), without for an instant stopping to consider the fact that the theory of H. Paul Grice, which served as a point of departure for many chapters, applies to the American model but not to the French one. The implicit character of the theory having naturally escaped French researchers, more than one of them attacked it, after having implicitly presented it as universal. (As Grice’s text was written in English, it is difficult to know if he was aware of its cultural implications. I do not, however, believe that he saw its cultural limitations.)

What does conversation mean to the French? In French, we say that a conversation must be "engaged," "sustained," "fueled," and "revived" if it is "dragging," "rerouted" if it is "dangerous." Once we permit a conversation to begin, we owe it to ourselves to keep it from dying, to care for it, to guide it, to nourish it, and to watch over its development as if it were a living creature. This is enough to suggest the importance we place on conversation, but it does not explain the meaning we attribute to it, that is to say, why we give it this importance.

Let's see what happens in a simple conversation between two French people. I (the speaker) look at my interlocutor, watch for signs of boredom or inattention. If the other person's gaze begins to stray, to wander, I change my behavior, my tactic, or the subject, or else I cut myself short to allow him or her to speak. Of course, we are not talking about what truly happens in most cases but of the norm, the "ideal" situation which remains unchanged, no matter how often the rule is broken. In the inverse case (someone is speaking to me), I have several means at my disposal to intervene or to indicate that I want to speak: facial expressions, lips which open as if to say something but remain silent, slight body movements, or gestures. If this does not obtain the desired result and I still am unable to speak, I must make use of other signs—a barely audible inhalation which indicates that I am going to speak, a discreet sigh, a chopped-off word—or the stratagems of last resort—"speaking of which" "funny you should mention that"—which in general have nothing to do with the preceding conversation but rather indicate that I would like to say something too. If I start to look distracted or take on a vacant stare, it is to indicate, in what is still an acceptable manner, that I am ready to abandon the conversation since there is no place in it for me. If this has no effect, my only hope lies in the intervention of a third party (a friend met fortuitously on the street, a host or hostess, a guest, or a table companion at a meal or party) to save me from this "pain in the neck." If worse comes to worst, I can avail myself of the excuses that have the disadvantage of being obvious: a telephone call to make, something urgent to tell someone else that I almost forgot, and the like. When I am pushed to this extreme, I am really resentful at the other for having "cornered" me, for having "kept me" (and therefore held me against my wishes), for having "monopolized the conversation" for "hours"—in short, for

not having "given" me a chance to speak, that is, for having refused me all meaningful presence.

The fact that I allowed X to "hold me back" in this way suggests that something else was holding me back, something stronger than my impatience or my boredom, something I call manners but which encompasses an entire gamut of implicitly accepted social obligations. What is more, the many signals at my disposal for attracting X's attention, and to which X should be sensitive and respond, suggest that the relationship between two people engaged in conversation is more important than the mere subject of the conversation, more important than the amount of information exchanged. This assertion is confirmed, I believe, in the case of conversations in which one "strays from the topic." I would say that whoever brings up a topic is completely free to stray from it and does so, most often, by the intermediary of "that reminds me of . . .," "why just the other day . . .," "that makes me think of . . .," and so on. These departures from the topic, these "side trips," so to speak, allow the conversants to continue speaking while holding at bay the need for the signs of intervention mentioned earlier. There is, in a sense, a suspension of conversational expectations, just as we follow without complaining someone who gives us a tour of his garden and draws our attention to such and such a path. Meanwhile, it is possible for the other conversants to intervene, and to speak in turn, simply by means of "to get back to . . .," though they are not obliged to return to the original topic. In fact, someone who shows a certain insistence on returning to a topic would be considered boorish or childish, desirous of drawing attention to himself, and would create an annoyance (or worse, a rupture in the conversation).

Here again, the important thing is to establish ties, to create a network, tenuous as it may be, between the conversants. The exchange of words, in the "thread" of conversation, serves to weave these ties between the speakers. If we imagine a conversation as being a spider's web, we can see the exchanging of words as playing the role of the spider, generating the threads which bind the participants. The ideal (French) conversation would resemble a perfect spider's web: delicate, fragile, elegant, brilliant, of harmonious proportions, a work of art. If there are many more perfect spider's webs than there are ideal conversations, it is because the spider is alone in weaving its web,

like
Sany's
perfect
moments
(Sany, 'Nauvra')

whereas conversations require at least two participants. The danger and the risk of error are thus far greater (sometimes we even get tangled in the web). The character of a particular conversation and its form therefore reflect, with a great deal of exactitude for whoever takes the trouble to read the signs, the nature of the relationship between the conversants. We create the fabric of our relationship in the same way and at the same time that we "make" conversation.

Thus, for example, if I run errands in the neighborhood, I'll "chat a bit" with the owners of the shops where I usually go. If I pick up my children at school, I'll do the same with parents whose children are in the same class as mine, and with the teacher if I see him or her. With the shopkeepers, I'll probably talk about the weather, our health, about the hard times (if they are so), about my family's preference for a particular product, about the beautiful variety of fruits, about an event which occurred in the street near the store, and so on. The closer our ties, the longer the conversation will be (within the limits imposed by the context, customers who are waiting, the time of day, etc.). With other parents, I will speak briefly about our children, about school, about the weather and about the most recent flu epidemic, unless there is something to organize (a meeting, a party). The conversation will rarely be a long one, as each of us is in a hurry to get back, to bring the children home. The length of the conversation will be limited by the circumstances (and the number of parents grouped together at the same time), and the nature of the conversation will be a direct reflection of the nature of our relationship (a polite, friendly, or warm exchange). In any case, it is important for there to be some sort of exchange, short as it may be. This explains why someone might say, "My God, I saw Madame Z outside the school, but I didn't even have time to stop and say a few words. What must she think?" In such a case, an American would have said "Hi," and that would have sufficed. Thus the American's surprise at "the time we spend" chatting with one another.

Another source of incomprehension for Americans: it is not only possible, but frequent, if I live in an apartment building with an elevator for example, for me to hold the door and say hello to my upstairs or downstairs neighbor (or even a next-door neighbor) and for us to ascend eight or fifteen flights together without saying another word to each other (except goodbye), perhaps even on a daily basis. But for me (French) there is no contradiction between the way I have

conversations in my neighborhood and the fact that I hardly speak to my immediate neighbors: it is only by chance that we live so close to each other, and this is not a sufficient reason for us to develop a relationship, unless of course we specifically choose to do so. Similarly, on a small, quiet, provincial street, it suffices for me to nod my head and to say hello to the neighbors who live next door and across the street (unless an extraordinary event interrupts the routine).

In the same way, while a customer's "hello" or "goodbye," in France, is directed at everyone in the store, conversation occurs only between the customer and the shopkeeper, and not among customers (even if they see each other there every day), unless it occurs through the intermediary of the shopkeeper ("Why don't you ask Madame Z") or because of an exceptional event (an accident, a demonstration in the streets). A better example of this situation can be seen in cafés. I have several choices in a café. I can go with someone, remain at the counter, and speak only to my companion; I can meet friends there, in which case we sit at a table, or the first one to arrive sits at the table we will occupy. We talk among ourselves. I can also go alone and take a table if I want "to be left alone," and I can read, write a novel, or write letters, without speaking to anyone except the waiter (and even then, only to order). If, however, I do nothing but drink whatever it is I am drinking and look around me (or at someone in particular) insistently, I give the impression that I am there for a "pickup" (a continual source of problems for unsuspecting American women). If I feel like having a conversation, I'll settle in at the counter, where I can chat only with the owner of the café or whoever is standing behind the counter. I can also start up a conversation with someone at the counter, but only via the café owner, and only if I am already a regular customer; if not, my move will seem suspicious. This is why the café owner must know how to "talk" with all kinds of people. Every day, in a small café in La Rochelle (where I conducted many interviews), students, workers, policemen, and employees rub elbows. The café owner described the situation in these terms: "You don't need a fancy education to own a café, to talk with people . . . about everything. . . . Even if you don't know much about it, you can still talk. . . . The café is a place where people meet each other. . . . We talk . . . about business, sports, work, about granny's illness . . . about anything. . . . They have their little habits which we're familiar with; we make friends more or less, with some of them. . . . They all get along just fine . . . stu-

dents, cops, they manage to agree." Then, underlining the essential role which the café owner plays in these unexpected exchanges (between students and cops, for example), he continues, "it really depends on the person behind the counter. . . . People come for the ambience of the café, but also for the person who's behind the counter. . . . That's what determines the clientele, in fact."

An experienced observer has no problem recognizing the clientele, the regulars, as we can see if we go back to the example of the shopkeeper, an example which has the advantage of being readily accessible, of being observable by everyone, even by those who rarely go to cafés. In a small Parisian bakery in which I made many recordings, I was able to hear an entire gamut of conversations between the bakery owner and her customers within just a few hours. If we exclude the polite exchanges common to all of them ("hello," "please," "thank you," "goodbye"), we can quickly distinguish a few telltale signs. For example, the purely informational exchanges ("What would you like?" "A *baguette*" "Well-browned?" "Yes." "Here you are, it's such-and-such a price") clearly indicate the nonregulars; strictly speaking, there was no conversation. The rare regulars who chose not to converse (due to shyness, reserve, misanthropy) were distinguishable from the preceding by the fact that they did not need to be told the price of the bread, or else, and especially, by the gestures of the baker, who turned toward a particular kind of bread while saying, for example, "*un batard* (thick loaf of bread)" or "*une ficelle* (long, thin loaf of bread) as usual?" Otherwise, the regulars were entitled to a conversation, as short as it may have been ("Feeling better today?" in which the "better" and "today" suggest other days, and therefore, economically, the relationship). There are regulars who are addressed as Madame or Monsieur, those who are addressed as Monsieur Z or Madame Z, and then those who are addressed by their first names (and with whom the baker uses the informal "you" form, *tu*). There are those who are asked about the "children" or the "little ones," those who are asked about "your daughter/grandson/wife/mother," and those who are asked about "Gaston," "Nicole," or "Arthurine." There are those who go directly to the counter (they are in a rush, have a brief conversation) and those who wait on the side and let other customers pass (they know the baker rather well, and are going to have a longer, more intimate conversation). And then there are those rare customers who are admitted to the back room (who are asked about all

the members of their family, whom the baker refers to and names by their first names, etc.). In this case, the bread is mentioned and purchased almost as an afterthought; it is paid for in the same way, or just added to "the bill" (which these days is a sign of a solid relationship). It seems therefore that between the regular customer and the shopkeeper, conversation transforms what would normally be a purely economic transaction into a social exchange and therefore into a tie to be reinforced or maintained.

It is now clear, I believe, that the French do not talk "without saying anything" and that, on the contrary, French conversation is loaded with meaning, especially in that it affirms and reveals the nature of the ties between the conversers. But in what way does this analysis explain the first situation mentioned at the beginning of this chapter—in what way does this analysis give meaning to X's seemingly "disconnected" phrases while he was driving me home? To understand this monologue, which seems abnormal, we must consider it to be a conversation reduced to the bare essentials, to what is necessary and sufficient in the situation at hand. In fact, the commentaries that X seems to pour out "for no reason" play an important role: they acknowledge my presence. In addition, they reveal that close or fairly close ties already exist between X and me, that we are comfortable enough together not to have to converse if we do not particularly feel like it: X may be a member of my family (my mother, my son, my wife, my brother), a boyfriend or girlfriend, a close buddy, an old friend, and so on. If this were not the case, X would not indulge in his little monologue but would "make" conversation, would engage me in a verbal exchange by asking questions that would require answers rather than questions that, on the contrary, do not call for any, since they are asked, if you remember, at the very moment when the action is taking place ("Do I turn right here?" while turning). If, on the other hand, X, with whom I have close ties, drove me home in silence, it could signify boredom, a bad mood, or anger. The silence might quickly become heavy, menacing—in any case a sign of rejection and of difficulty (unless I know X to be taciturn, "quiet"). If the silence were mutual, due to fatigue, for example, we would, at least briefly, comment upon it ("I'm bushed"; "It's so quiet, so nice") and thereby explain it.

At the other extreme, in the absence of any relationship, silence is

neutral, if not hostile. This is why in the elevator, in the street, on the bus, and in practically every place where the other is almost totally foreign to my daily life, where the context does not call for ties to be formed or else lends itself to misunderstandings, "people don't talk to each other readily in France." We can be both complete strangers and completely glued to one another in France, as in the métro during rush hour, or in the airport when the boarding of a plane has been announced but has not yet begun. Speaking is what brings us closer to each other.

This is a seemingly inexhaustible source of misunderstanding between the French and Americans, especially since, to complicate matters, these rules are suspended under exceptional circumstances and on vacation (and therefore on the train, on the plane). It is indeed in public places that Americans in France for the first time have the experience, at times amusing, but often unpleasant and even painful, of cultural misunderstanding. They feel rejected, disapproved of, criticized, or scorned without understanding the reason for this "hostility," and they can draw only one of two conclusions: "the French hate Americans," or "the French are cold (hostile/unpleasant/arrogant/despicable)." And the buried wound becomes an entrenched conviction, constantly reinforced. This is essentially due to the fact that Americans and the French do not attribute the same meaning to verbal exchanges yet believe their meanings to be identical. Thus the astonishment when faced with unexpected results, the incomprehension when faced with disjunction in what should "go without saying."

When one American passes another on the street, in the middle of the day and in a neighborhood not known to be dangerous, there is a good chance, if one exchanges glances with the other, that he or she will smile or nod, or even say hello to the stranger, without it going any further. This often surprises French visitors in the United States. As a respectable, gray-haired man said to me, "If I were younger, I would think all these pretty girls were giving me the eye. . . . They seem like such flirts when they smile at you like that. . . . If this were France. . . ." This same sudden and fleeting rapport among strangers can be established just as well through conversation in the United States, here again without consequence. It can even last a long time, as at American dinners and parties, at which one meets "very nice" people, with whom one has long conversations, and whom one will never see again (which French people find deeply disturbing).

In this respect it is interesting to compare what happens in France and in the United States in the supermarket when the store is crowded, with a long line in front of the cash register and a long wait. In France, in most cases, one quickly shows signs of impatience, by raising one's eyes to the ceiling with an exasperated expression, by taking on an exhausted look, by stiffening or clammng up, or by exchanging with others glances of complicity. But one does not speak to others—all is expressed through body movements. At most, one might protest, "grumble" out loud while looking at one's neighbor, but without speaking to him directly. One simply makes him an accomplice against the cashier, the store, the system, those who are "going too far." In the United States, the situation is completely different. One turns to one's neighbors; people strike up rather general conversations, help each other pass the time, and joke about the situation—even sympathize with the cashier—and, when they finally get to the register, encourage the person there with a few kind words. I've seen strangers show each other family photos, exchange advice, recipes, or useful addresses, compare pregnancies and births, all just as calmly as if they were talking about the quality of a product or the use of an unusual vegetable in one's shopping cart. Most of all I've seen them joke around a lot. A French woman who heard me speaking French to a friend I had met in the supermarket introduced herself to us, gave us her address and telephone number, and invited us to come see her if we were passing by the city in which she lived. Then, just before leaving us, she apologized for her behavior by saying, "Excuse me for having come up to you like that, but I heard you speaking French. I've become very American, you know. . . ."

More than once, I have noticed that when the supermarket becomes very crowded, when it is difficult to move around or even to know in which line one is waiting, the atmosphere becomes partylike, fun-filled. And on these occasions, even though there are newspapers and magazines near each register to tempt customers and encourage them to be patient, few people choose to read, unless they mix their reading with conversation (commentaries on the headlines, the sensationalism of certain weeklies, etc.). Indeed, isolating oneself in reading and silence in such a restricted space could, I believe, signify a rejection of others.

A French person could see the confirmation of his stereotypes in all this ("Americans are good-natured," "Americans have superficial relationships," etc.) because for a French person, the following

opened → speaking, verbal interaction
b. strangers → very American
French → body language, signs of impatience . . .

"truth"—or cultural presupposition—is self-evident: conversation commits me to another person, it is a commentary on our relationship, one of the ways at my disposal to make the distinction between those with whom I have, affirm, confirm, or want to create ties, and all the others whose social importance in my life I deny by this refusal. These ties, one should note, are not necessarily pleasant; I may even bitterly regret having them, secretly dream of freeing myself of them, but insofar as I refuse or cannot afford the price of this break, these ties are essential to my social existence, they inscribe me in the social. But all this has settled in my mind unbeknownst to me, and I (as a French person) am generally unaware of possessing these implicit assumptions, this screen through which I see and understand the world. For this perspective, it is "normal" for me to find that Americans display a certain "promiscuity" in their conversations in the supermarket, as they do in their relationships (see the chapter on friendship). It is also "normal" for me to refuse all ties that I have not chosen (in the broadest sense), that have been imposed on me by circumstance, by chance, which assigns me certain neighbors, which places me next to others in the subway, in a store, on the street, in the check-out line at the supermarket, and so on.

Similarly, to the extent that I (as an American) do not feel bound by conversation because of the unconscious screen through which I see the world, I can make conversation almost anywhere with anyone. Furthermore, the nature of my relationship with another person can be determined not by our conversation but by the space I allow between us. The closer our relationship, the less space there will be between us, as is indicated metaphorically by the expression "a close-knit family." Thus, if by chance I find myself in a situation in which the space between another person and myself is smaller than the space which would "normally" express the nature of our relationship (or the absence of one), I can always resort to conversation to recreate the involuntarily diminished distance. If I cannot move away from a person who is literally invading my relational space, I redress the balance with conversation, and all goes well if the other person and I are both American, since we will both "spontaneously" be drawn toward the same solution (the other doesn't want me in his or her relational space either if I am a stranger).

We can now imagine the potential for misunderstanding inherent in a very simple scenario: circumstances put a French person and an

American together in a limited space, at a table in the dining car of a train, for example. The French person will recreate distance with silence, the American with conversation. The degree zero of an American conversation would therefore be the smile I address to a stranger I pass in the street, and with whom I exchange glances—if I look elsewhere, I am not obliged to do anything. But the empty stare, the stare that passes through the other without seeing him or her, is not an American specialty. If I want to avoid the other's gaze, I look elsewhere (as in the New York subways, where it is dangerous to smile blissfully). If my gaze meets the other's gaze and I do not greet him or her, do not smile, or do not quickly look away, this exchange of glances becomes the equivalent of a reduction in our relational space and can take on connotations of seduction or suggest a challenge or insult, depending on the context.

I would like to stop a moment on this question of space. For an American, I repeat, it is the space between oneself and the other that reveals the nature of their relationship, not their conversation. This space is therefore clearly marked for whoever knows how to read the signs. Americans obey these rules automatically, of course, without thinking about them and even without being aware of them, since they have become "natural," which in this case means "cultural." I (an American) will not permit physical contact, and therefore the ultimate reduction in the space between us, except with certain people with whom I have a very close and clearly defined relationship. I can therefore hug (literally, "embrace") my parents, grandparents, brothers and sisters, children, and other members of my family, my friends, my spouse, or my lover. If I embrace a person of the opposite sex, the fact that we pat each other on the back toward the end of the embrace indicates, according to my interpretation, that our relationship is neither a sexual nor a romantic one. (The many Americans to whom I disclosed the role I attribute to this patting on the back, against which the French body rebels, were not even aware of doing it. Many of my students told me they had hurried to verify my theory and to test it out by observing others and themselves, and then confirmed my interpretation, grumbling about it in a friendly way: I had made them aware of a totally "spontaneous" gesture, and suddenly they saw themselves doing it. May the American reader beware of this, and not hold it against me!) Since the days of the hippies, we can observe variations in this pat on the back: young people today may prefer a more or less

noticeable swaying from side to side of the two "embracing" bodies. This embrace, tight or loose, long or short, according to the relationship expressed, takes place in silence.

This behavior explains why, when I find myself against my will very near to a person I don't know, I will speak to try to reestablish the distance. Otherwise, if we are in a limited space, or we touch, and I don't say anything, my silence will seem suggestive and become a sexual invitation. This is why the rush hour (French) subway is such a traumatizing experience, since my (American) efforts to reestablish the distance with words correspond, for a French person, to a suggestive invitation. And the accusations of promiscuity fly in both directions (touch anybody, talk to anybody). It is interesting to notice here that when the implicit rule has been broken, it is with words that violence is initiated in the French context and with silent space reduction in the American.

When my space is not threatened, (American) conversation will allow me to "become acquainted" with the other and will give him or her information that will allow him or her to become acquainted with me. But this is true only for the present, within the limits defined by the context, and without any obligation for us to maintain the relationship, since conversation is not a commentary on our relationship but rather an exploration. American conversation is closer to a hike with two or more people in unknown territory than to a game on familiar territory—hence the need immediately to situate the participants (the territory) and the importance of cooperation. Each person will contribute to the exploration according to his or her knowledge and capacities. We may return from this hike with our hands empty or full, depending on the moment, the mood, and the quality of each person's contribution. Consequently, if I (an American) am unsure of my information, I do not pretend to know but let whoever might know more speak. But if I have something to "contribute," I can speak as long as seems necessary to respond to a question, to share my information. And I will listen to the other in the same way when it is his or her turn, no matter what the other's style may be. And since when I am finished, I will spontaneously stop speaking, the other person will wait for this silence, different from that of a thoughtful pause, to speak in turn. Any other kind of behavior would look like an insulting interruption to me; I would interpret it as a sign of lack of interest or, even worse, as frivolous and annoying, as contributing nothing more than

"noise," "senseless commotion," or signs of "impatience" to the conversation. In short, the interruption is more a commentary on the person who interrupts than on the person who is interrupted. We can now understand why Americans are shocked by the "rudeness" of French people who "interrupt you all the time."

But if it is true that in the French context silence allows me to create distance, it then follows, according to my cultural logic, that the closer people are, the less silence there will be, and the more the conversation will be "animated," "lively." We can therefore understand why French people "often ask questions without waiting for an answer," according to Americans. Seen in its cultural context, this mode of conduct becomes not reprehensible because impolite but, on the contrary, normal, that is to say, in conformity with the norm. The question that is asked, but for which no answer is awaited, is in fact a way of indicating interest. When I (a French person) ask another person questions in the course of conversation, it is more to manifest my interest in him or her than to obtain information, to become informed. The most obvious example, of course, is "how are you?" (*comment allez-vous?*), but the gamut of such questions is wide. If, in addition to showing interest, I really want information, to learn as many details as possible, I can always ask the question again, formulate it in several ways, or make it more specific if the response seems too vague or if it intrigues me and arouses my curiosity. Hence the impatience of the French when faced with long, detailed responses, which "go all the way back to Adam and Eve" or "turn into lectures" and "monopolize" the conversation. In the French context, it is therefore the person who provides a literal (and hence overly long) response to a question who can be accused of being rude. This is a classic case of intercultural misunderstanding, illustrated by the second situation described at the beginning of this essay. By asking the American historian his opinion of a particular book, the French academic, at the party in his honor, was simply trying to begin a conversation (in French style) and did not really want an American-style response to his question (which involves sharing the information one possesses). If the French person really wanted an opinion on the book, he would have asked the question much later in the conversation, after having explained, in one way or another, why one historian's opinion of another interested him, a nonhistorian who had his own views on the question, and only after having created a relationship and

thus established the "credibility" (according to him) of his interlocutor and hence the "validity" of his opinion. By asking his question immediately after an introduction, he was merely using it to begin a conversation, "tossing it out" like a ball. Obviously, in this case, one does not expect the other person to keep the ball but to toss it back, and so on.

Long, uninterrupted responses, attentively listened to, are reserved, by French people, for so-called serious conversations, which are out of place at a party, or in any similar context, because they isolate the group that is "talking seriously" from the rest of the possible conversers, who might feel excluded or rejected, and rightfully so. Moreover, if two or three people have this type of conversation within a larger group, they will, whether unconsciously or purposely, spatially isolate themselves from the rest of the group, in the corner of a room, for example. This will be accepted for a while by the other members of the group at hand, who will tacitly understand that they shouldn't "bother them," go near them, or interrupt them. In exchange, these two or three people will tacitly know that they cannot prolong this isolation too long without being "rude," without insulting the rest of the group, which "is going to wonder what's going on" or very simply abandon them to their "heated discussion." It is worth noting that one "has" a serious conversation or a discussion, whereas one "makes" conversation (in French as in English). It is in the context of a serious French conversation that the American will be most at ease because it corresponds most closely to his own definition of conversation.

Even more than the questions that do not require true answers, it is the "continual interruptions" in French conversation that baffle Americans. But, as we should expect by now, what an American takes for an interruption is not really an interruption but plays a completely different role in French conversation. Seen from the exterior, French people engaged in conversation do indeed seem to spend their time interrupting one another. The conversation seems pleasant nonetheless, and the participants give no sign of annoyance, frustration, or impatience (to the French observer, that is). On the contrary, interruptions seem to be a driving force in the conversation. It is therefore permitted, at certain moments and not at others, to interrupt the conversation without being rude. To know which moments are appropriate, one need only consider the "interruption" as a punctuation

mark. It is in no way a matter of cutting someone off in the middle of a word or sentence but, rather, of seizing the pause, brief as it may be, to react. I do not interrupt to draw attention to myself or to speak in turn but to show my interest in the other's remark, which merits a commentary, a word of appreciation, denial, protest, or laughter—in short, a reaction, without which the remark would "fall flat." The ball is tossed to be caught and tossed back. When there is no "interruption," when each person speaks sedately in turn (as in American conversation, according to the French), the conversation never "takes off"; it remains polite, formal, cold.

The interruption-punctuations, then, are proof of spontaneity, enthusiasm, and warmth, a source of unpredictability, interest and stimulation, a call for participation and pleasure. They are the ties that bind, that bring the conversants closer together. This explains why very animated conversations (at cafés for instance) are a source of pleasure and stimulation (just like a wild game of soccer on the beach). These conversations take place among people who have already established a relationship (that of being "old regulars" may be sufficient in order to "talk politics"), who meet at the café expecting such conversations. The rhythm of the exchange, the tone of the voices, and the frequency of the laughter are indications of the pleasure that the participants draw from the conversation. The faster the rhythm, the higher the voices go, and the more the exchange is punctuated with laughter, until the final explosion. For an unsuspecting American (and in this case, they are in the majority), the rapidity of the exchange may be interpreted as a series of interruptions (and therefore an indication of aggression) and the tone of the voice as an expression of anger. (When my daughter was little, she asked me one day why I always fought with my French friends who came to the house and never with my American friends; that was probably the day that I began my cultural analyses.) As for the laughter-punctuation, it becomes one more "proof," for an American, that "French people laugh for no reason," "aren't serious." An American will also find it extremely difficult to participate in a French conversation even if he or she speaks French perfectly, which is a very frustrating experience.

Similarly, the rhythm of American conversation, the tone of voice to adopt, and the place for laughter can be forever misunderstood or mysterious. For me (a French person who speaks American fluently), the rhythm is slow and always the same, and my efforts to accelerate

the rhythm are constantly submerged in the unalterable wave of words that engulfs those efforts. My laughter will always seem out of place, and my attempts to participate will be treated as untimely interruptions. What may be most difficult to swallow is that the American interlocutor seems blind to all my signals (indicating that I want to speak), may be conscious of them without responding to them, or may go so far as to utter calmly the terribly "insulting" phrase, "Let me finish." And to add to it all, the American interlocutor doesn't even look at me.

Indeed, if we remember, looking someone straight in the eyes means (to the American) invading the other's relational space. I (as an American) will therefore only look at my interlocutor from time to time, without allowing my gaze to "linger." For these same reasons, I am not obliged to look at each conversant one by one (as a French person would do in order to include all those present in the conversation), but only to shoot rapid circular glances at the group. Similarly, if my interlocutor looks elsewhere, this does not necessarily indicate a lack of interest. If, in addition, one of my pauses was interpreted by my interlocutor as the final pause of my discourse (thus it is his or her turn to speak), I can indicate the error simply by saying "I haven't finished" (which is not a reprimand for rudeness, as a French person would interpret it).

The ideal American conversation does not seek to evoke fireworks, as can be the case for French conversation but, in my opinion, is closer to a jazz session, even a "jam session." Just like a jazz musician, who can bring his musical instrument, join a group of musicians he does not know, play with them, and leave, disappearing forever into the night, so I, in theory, can join a conversation if I have something to add, learn from the conversation, and then disappear forever into the night. Just as in a jazz session each musician plays his solo as he wishes, without interruption, so I can speak according to my style and my talent, without interruption. Like the jazz musician, I will have learned, through a long apprenticeship, to recognize the moment when the other person's solo has finished and when to begin (and end) my own. The discordant notes are the loud voices, the "excited" tone, and the laughter "about nothing," which hinder the understanding and accord necessary for the group to create a piece of music. The only acceptable accompaniments are the slight, muffled sounds ema-

nating from the throats of my interlocutors, which indicate, in a minimal and efficient manner (one or two notes should suffice), their comprehension, agreement, surprise, and so on, simply by use of varying intonations.

This is why it is easier (not impossible) to speak a foreign language perfectly, without an accent, that it is the "speak" another culture "without an accent"—without my cultural "accent" putting me in difficulty even if, masked by my linguistic performance, it does not immediately betray my difference. The case of people who have been perfectly bilingual since childhood is interesting in this respect. Thus, X is Franco-American, bilingual and bicultural. It may happen that X, in a conversation in American with Americans, unconsciously adopts the French rhythm and tone of voice. X may then be considered aggressive, quibbling, or noisy by the other conversants, which will surprise and hurt X. Similarly, X, speaking French to French people, might adopt the implicit rules of American conversation without realizing it, and may therefore be considered "slow," "heavy," insistent or dominating, too serious. In both cases, the cultural difference being neither obvious nor even conceivable, X's "fault" is credited to his or her personality. The consequences for X might be more serious if X is unaware of the possible clashes between these two cultures.

In conclusion, I would briefly like to return to language, which seems to summarize the difference between American conversation and French conversation. Centuries ago, "to converse" (*converser*) meant, in French, "to live with someone," "to frequent," a meaning which is still alive in today's French conversation. In American, on the other hand, conversation is "an informal verbal exchange of thoughts," and "to be conversant" means "to know by experience or study," that is to say, "to be a specialist in, good at, exercised in, well informed, capable."